

KEY FIGURE

FREDERICK
THE GREAT
1740–86

Frederick the Great (Frederick II, King of Prussia) was the most admired commander of his time. His greatest battles were at Rossbach and Leuthen, in November and December, 1757, during the Seven Years' War. He won each victory against far larger forces, through aggressive battlefield manoeuvres.



▲ Frederick commanded his army in person, priding himself upon his tactical handling of artillery, cavalry, and the disciplined Prussian infantry.

► CUIRASSIER'S
UNIFORM

Cuirassiers were French heavy cavalry who wore plumed helmets. Their tunics were less spectacular than those of the light cavalry, but they were usually covered by armour – a cuirass and back plate.



► THE BATTLE OF BLENHEIM

A British army led by the Duke of Marlborough, and Austrian forces under Eugene of Savoy, defeated Franco-Bavarian forces at Blenheim, in 1704, during the War of Spanish Succession. More than 30,000 soldiers were killed or wounded in the day's fighting.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

18TH-CENTURY
UNIFORMED ARMIES

The armies that fought such conflicts as the wars of the Spanish Succession (1701–14) and Austrian Succession (1740–48), the Seven Years' War (1756–63), and the American Revolutionary War (1775–83), followed the tradition of uniformed regular forces, with a formal hierarchy of ranks.

Permanent regiments, identified by banners, uniforms, and other symbols, provided a focus for loyalty. Cavalry retained high status and were given important tasks: light horsemen carried out reconnaissance and raids, while heavy cavalry were used in field battles to charge with sabres drawn. Although field artillery was growing in use, muzzle-loaded smoothbore cannon as yet played only a supporting role. Consequently, the success or failure of an army depended mainly upon its infantry.

MUSKETS AND RIFLES

Around the start of the 18th century, European infantry adopted the flintlock musket and socket bayonet. The bayonet replaced the pike, in effect making every foot soldier a musketeer. Usually recruited from the lowest levels of society, infantry were subject to brutal discipline and relentlessly drilled to execute orders without question. They were trained to manoeuvre with mechanical precision, marching in columns and deploying in lines for combat, to bring maximum firepower to bear. Since armour was no longer used, soldiers walked unprotected into enemy muskets and cannon, while maintaining close formation. They shot their muskets in controlled volleys, relying on volume of fire rather than individual marksmanship.

Alongside the line infantry, European armies deployed light infantry, who were supposed to take on a freer role. Some of these light troops, notably the Austrian and Prussian Jäger, were armed with rifles. Line infantry were not trained in aimed fire, which was hardly possible with the inherently inaccurate smoothbore musket. The Jäger were accomplished sharpshooters, however, capable of accurate sniping and skilled in the use of cover. Elsewhere, rifle-armed American frontiersmen gained a legendary reputation for success against the British Army in the American War of Independence, although the reality was not as clearly defined.

HEAVY LOSSES

The level of combat casualties during this period was often astonishingly high. At the Battle of Zorndorf in 1758, during the Seven Years' War, the Prussians suffered 11,000 casualties out of an army of 36,000, while the Russians lost 22,000 men out of 43,000. Commanders such as Frederick the Great aspired to battles of sweeping manoeuvre, making coordinated use of infantry, cavalry, and artillery to achieve victories. Some battles, however, simply degenerated into incoherent mêlées, obscured by great clouds of gunpowder smoke. Although many European armies had developed into highly efficient killing machines, commanders typically found it difficult to translate successes on the battlefield into permanent strategic gains.

